GymBuddy
Product Documentation

AI-powered self-guided fitness companion for beginner gym-goers

AI note: GymBuddy is AI-powered by design; the prototype implements the PRD's bounded plan-selection logic deterministically rather than using a live LLM call.

Challenge: PML Product Challenge Date: 23 Sep 2026

Core user: First-time / early-stage gym-goers in India, first 0-6 months, training mostly alone at a physical gym.

> *“Tell me exactly what to do at the gym, help me complete it, and show me that I'm staying on track.”*

Product thesis: Remove the guesswork of the next gym session and make progress legible through a user-defined target, guided execution, and a simple return loop.

Challenge framework
Understand → Prioritise → Build → Test → Learn

This compact document consolidates the product strategy, research evidence, requirements, AI approach, prototype scope, metrics, risks, validation plan, GTM direction, decisions and traceability behind the final presentation.

1. Executive Summary

Field	Definition
Product	GymBuddy - AI-powered self-guided workout companion for beginner gym-goers.
Target	First-time / early-stage gym-goers in India; 0-6 months; mostly training alone; no personal trainer; general fitness goal.
Context	Offline gym + phone companion: onboard → set target → follow plan → complete/log → see progress → return.
Core problem	Beginners lack a clear structured plan, do not know what to do during each visit, cannot tell if it is working, and may become inconsistent and drop off.
Core value	One unambiguous personalised session plan + a beginner-legible progress signal, without trainer cost.
Core action	Complete today's guided session and log it.
V1 focus	Guided onboarding, personal target, bounded AI plan, Today's Workout, exercise guidance, completion/logging, progress, streak and return trigger.

Core hypothesis

If GymBuddy removes uncertainty around what a beginner should do and gives them a visible, personally relevant progress signal against a target they set themselves, users may be more likely to complete workouts and return. This remains a product hypothesis, not a proven de-risker.

What GymBuddy is not

Not an online fitness-instructor platform, live trainer marketplace, home workout product, open-ended AI fitness chatbot, or full nutrition platform.

2. User, Problem & Research Direction

Target user

• Profile: first-time / early-stage gym-goers in India, 0-6 months.

• Environment: budget chain, boutique studio, or housing-society/apartment gym; mostly self-directed.

• Needs: a low-effort “what do I do today?” answer, a legible progress signal, and low-pressure guidance.

• Workarounds: copies others, uses borrowed screenshots, generic PDFs/YouTube routines, community programs, cardio, or asks staff/friends.

Problem statement

First-time gym-goers in India join with a general-fitness goal but, faced with unfamiliar equipment, no affordable expert guidance, and a flood of generic or conflicting advice, do not know what to do on any given visit. Because they lack a beginner-legible way to tell whether it is working, doubt compounds over time and drop-off becomes more likely.

Desired outcome

“I know what to do when I walk in, and I can see it's working.”

Key research patterns

Pattern	Evidence documented in PRD	Confidence / implication
No structure	Recurring forum pattern around “don't know what to do”; a paid-PDF market exists to solve it.	High → prioritise a structured answer to today's workout.
Early drop-off	~50% quit within 6 months; 47-54% stop attending within 3 months (Oliveira 2021, Gjestvang 2021, Sperandei 2016).	High → design the core loop around return, not just first-use activation.
Gym intimidation	Sure Women survey: 1 in 4 women avoid exercise for fear of judgment; #shygirlworkout has 315M+ views.	High → low-pressure guidance and zero-ambiguity execution.
Progress ambiguity	Recurring questions such as “am I doing this right?” and “should I switch programs”.	Medium → add a beginner-legible progress signal.
Choice overload	Fortune 2026 app-testing panel and app reviews flag beginner overload.	Medium-high → keep onboarding and V1 deliberately narrow.
AI reliability	Documented AI-as-trainer test produced an unsafe plan and inconsistent reprompts.	Medium → constrain AI to a pre-vetted library + bounded adjustment.
Structure-first trust	Fitloop built on community routines had 32,000+ users praising simplicity.	High → structure is part of the value proposition.

Evidence gap to validate

India-specific evidence from budget-gym / housing-society self-directed beginners is limited in the research pass. The India problem framing is therefore a working assumption that the planned user-validation round should probe.

3. Supporting Research Evidence

Source record

Source / platform	Finding captured	Use in GymBuddy
Forums / fitness communities	Recurring “don't know what to do” and “am I doing this right?” patterns.	Core problem + need for structure / progress legibility.
Sure Women survey (n=2,000)	1 in 4 women avoid exercise for fear of judgment.	Guidance should reduce gym intimidation and judgment pressure.
Oliveira 2021	Attendance / retention evidence supporting early drop-off.	Return-focused metric and first-90-day framing.
Gjestvang 2021	Attendance drops within early months.	Reinforces early-retention focus.
Sperandei 2016	Attendance / retention evidence.	Supports the quantified drop-off problem.
Fortune 2026 app-testing panel	Beginner choice overload appears in fitness-app testing.	Justifies short onboarding and focused V1.
FitOn / MyFitCoach / PUSH reviews	Beginner overload / choice complexity appears in reviews.	Supports simple, guided execution.
Trainer pricing forum evidence	Forum references to ~$45+/hr and accountability products as a financial workaround.	Supports affordability positioning.
AI-as-trainer test	Unsafe marathon plan one week before race + inconsistent reprompts.	Supports bounded AI instead of open chat.
Fitloop / r/Fitness	32,000+ users and simplicity praise documented in PRD.	Supports structure-first product positioning.
cult.fit reviews	Mostly billing/support/booking complaints; weak proxy for GymBuddy's target problem.	Used cautiously; not treated as direct validation.
India-context Blind post	Confusion from too much routine/info + afford-a-trainer barrier.	Partial India-context support; still insufficient for full India validation.

Source metadata note

The attached PRD records source names, findings and confidence but does not contain complete source URLs for every item. This document preserves the source record without inventing links.

Representative persona

Meera (illustrative) - mid-20s, India metro/tier-1, first-time self-directed gym user, general fitness goal, has tried at least one fitness/class-booking app and abandons apps that front-load too many choices.

4. Product Strategy & Prioritisation

Layer	Decision
Vision	Become the default first stop for a first-time Indian gym-goer who does not know what to do.
Core value	One unambiguous, personalised session plan + a legible progress signal.
Core action	Complete today's guided session and log it.
Retention mechanism	User-defined monthly workout target + cadence-matched streak, rather than a daily streak.
Design principle	Encouraging, low-pressure, no guilt framing; rest days are normal.

V1 / V2 / Cut

Bucket	Features	Why
V1 - Must	Onboarding; personal target; AI-selected session plan; Today's Workout; exercise guidance; set/workout completion; session logging; progress; target progress; streak; next-workout trigger.	Everything needed to test the core loop: remove “what do I do?” uncertainty + make consistency/progress visible.
V2 - Later	Camera form/posture; social/friends/leaderboards; nutrition/macros; trainer marketplace/live chat; deeper personalisation.	Higher complexity, separate problem spaces, or weaker evidence; should follow V1 validation.
Cut	Open-ended AI chat; full diet/calorie planning; wearables; advanced competitive programming; gym/equipment booking; parallel weekly + monthly targets.	Does not directly test the chosen problem and/or adds unnecessary complexity/safety surface.

Key product decisions

Decision	Rationale	Confidence
First-time gym-goers as primary segment	Root “where do I start?” problem subsumes other candidate subgroups.	High
Personal target instead of fixed/daily habit	Keeps the consistency signal aligned with the user's own realistic cadence and avoids punitive daily framing.	Medium / hypothesis
Constrained AI, not open chat	AI selects/adjusts inside a fixed library with safety bounds.	Medium; needs validation
Today's Workout as core screen	Direct answer to the highest-signal problem: “what do I do right now?”	High
Return metric over DAU/MAU	Workout-cadence product; the hypothesis concerns coming back for another session.	High

5. User Journey / Core Loop

Stage	Purpose	Success condition
Entry	Show “can this help me?” in one screen.	User starts.
Onboarding	Capture experience, gym access, days/week in ≤5 questions.	Required inputs complete.
Personal target	Let the user set an editable monthly target.	Target saved before plan generation.
Personalised plan	Select/sequence a session from a pre-vetted library.	Plan generated / fallback available.
Today's Workout	Answer “what do I do right now?”.	User starts first exercise.
Exercise guidance	Explain how to do each movement + substitute.	User completes sets.
Complete + log	Capture completion and effort.	Session marked complete with required effort rating.
Progress / target	Show sessions trend + completed/target.	User sees a legible signal.
Streak	Show consecutive completion using user cadence.	Streak framed positively.
Next workout	Prompt the next session when due.	User returns and starts again.

V1 feature requirements - condensed

Feature	Core requirement	Critical behaviour
A. Onboarding	Experience level, gym access, days/week, optional limitations; ≤5 questions.	One question/screen; back allowed; resume on reopen; bodyweight fallback if no gym access.
B. Personal target	Single monthly target; presets 8/12/15/20 + custom.	Suggested from days/week; weekly/alternate-day input converts to monthly.
C. Personalised plan	Pre-vetted multi-week template; bounded next-session adjustment.	Easy → small increment; hard → hold; missed/partial → no jump; 10+ inactive → lighter restart.
D. Today's Workout	Exercises + sets/reps/rest + status.	Start exercise; fallback plan if fetch/generation fails; no dead ends.
E. Exercise guidance	Video or image+text fallback, sets/reps/rest, one substitute.	No blank state; fixed substitute mapping.
F. Set/workout completion	Mark sets and finish workout.	Partial session allowed; finish leads to log.

6. V1 Feature Requirements - Continued

Feature	Core requirement	Critical behaviour
G. Session logging	Effort required; weight/reps optional.	One required tap; writes session; feeds AI adjustment, progress, target, streak.
H. Progress trend	Session count + simple trend after ≥2 sessions.	Encouraging empty state; never blank/broken.
I. Target progress	Completed / target for current month.	Updates immediately; never red/negative framing; denominator changes immediately if target changes.
J. Personal streak	Cadence-matched consecutive session count.	Gap within grace window increments; late next log resets to 1; never 0 on logging.
K. Return trigger	Reminder from user cadence + “session due” state.	No duplicate same-day reminder; 10+ inactive → lighter welcome-back; disabled notifications fall back to in-app state.

Critical acceptance criteria

• End-to-end flow works with no dead ends: onboarding → target → plan → workout → guidance → completion → log → progress → target → streak → next workout.

• Every exercise has video or image+text fallback and a substitute where applicable.

• Session logging requires an effort rating; weight/reps remain optional.

• Target progress is encouraging and legible; streak increments/resets according to the cadence rules.

• Changing the target updates the current denominator without rewriting history or retroactively breaking a valid streak.

• No screen presents a blank or broken state.

UX essentials

Screen	Primary hierarchy / must-have
Onboarding + Target	One question in focus; progress indicator; ≤5 onboarding questions + target confirmation; editable target; Back available.
Today's Workout	Current exercise first; video/fallback prominent; sets/reps/rest secondary; swap action; Finish Workout at natural endpoint.
Progress / Target / Streak	Target ratio first; streak second; simple trend third; raw log last; encouraging empty states; Start Today when due.

7. AI Specification & Personal Target Logic

Constrained AI architecture

Layer	Definition
AI objective	Select/sequence a workout plan from a pre-vetted exercise/template library and adjust difficulty session-to-session.
Inputs	Experience level, gym/equipment access, days/week, optional limitations note, and session history (effort, completion, weight/reps).
Output	Structured plan object: exercises, sets, reps, rest - not conversational text.
Allowed	Only pre-vetted movements + fixed substitutions; bounded difficulty adjustments.
Deterministic	Library, substitutions, safety bounds, target/streak math.
AI-generated	Which approved template to use and how much to adjust within bounds.
Safety	No diagnosis/medical advice; pain/injury-adjacent input → conservative plan + professional guidance message.
Fallback	Plan-generation failure → single pre-built generic beginner plan; never blank.

Personal target & streak logic

Rule	Implementation
Target model	ONE stored monthly workout count; presets 8/12/15/20 or custom.
Conversion	Weekly count × 4.345, rounded; alternate days ≈ 15/month.
Expected interval	30 / monthly_target days.
Grace window	Expected interval × 1.5. Example: target 15 → 2-day expected interval → 3-day grace.
Streak increment	Gap since prior session ≤ grace_window → streak +1.
Reset	Gap > grace_window → next logged session shows streak = 1, never 0.
Idle	Opening the app while inactive does not visually “break” the streak; recalculation occurs on the next log.
Target change	New denominator applies immediately to current month; numerator/history untouched; future streak gaps use new grace window.
Month rollover	Target progress resets numerator to 0; streak continues across month boundary.
Tone	No red “broken” banners; no guilt countdowns; progress framed around completed sessions.

8. Metrics & Analytics

Primary metric

% of new users who complete a 2nd logged session within 14 days of their 1st. This tests return behaviour rather than only first-session activation.

Formula: (users with ≥2 logged sessions within 14 days of first session) ÷ (users with ≥1 logged session). Window: rolling 14 days, evaluated weekly.

Supporting + guardrail metrics

Type	Metric	Why
Supporting	Onboarding completion rate	Tests whether onboarding + target setup is short enough.
Supporting	First-session completion rate	Tests activation / day-1 feasibility.
Supporting	Session-log completion rate	Ensures progress/target/streak have data.
Supporting	Personal target completion rate	Tests whether self-set targets are achievable.
Supporting	Streak continuation rate	Tests whether the cadence-matched streak reflects sustained use.
Supporting	Video engagement rate	Tests whether exercise guidance is actually used.
Guardrail	Difficulty skew	Prevents AI adjustments drifting toward trivially easy sessions.
Guardrail	Notification opt-out / mute rate	Controls over-notification / guilt risk.
Guardrail	AI fallback rate	Detects broken personalisation path.
Guardrail	Streak-reset-after-target-change rate	Detects unintended streak breaks.

Minimum analytics events

onboarding_started; onboarding_step_completed; onboarding_abandoned; onboarding_completed; target_setup_shown; target_set; target_changed; plan_session_generated; plan_adjustment_applied; workout_started; workout_completed; exercise_video_played; exercise_substituted; set_marked_complete; session_logged; exercise_weight_logged; progress_view_opened; progress_trend_shown; target_progress_shown; streak_shown; streak_reset; return_notification_sent; return_notification_opened; reactivation_session_started.

Measurement status: Current product results are not yet measured; the baseline is to be established through V1 validation.

9. Risks, Prototype & Build

Risk	Likelihood / impact	Mitigation / next check
AI template/adjustment quality	Medium / High	Professional review of library; conservative bounds; validate perceived difficulty.
Personal target/streak feels arbitrary	Medium / Medium	Probe motivation vs. arbitrariness in first validation round.
India-specific evidence gap	Medium / Medium	Run India-based first-time gym user validation.
Punitive streak interpretation	Low-Medium / Medium	Positive framing; capped notifications; monitor guardrails.
Exercise content / licensing	High / Medium	Use limited prototype content; secure reviewed library before real users.
Unstated safety limitations	Medium / High	Conservative defaults + voluntary limitation note + medical disclaimer.

Prototype scope

Production requirement	Prototype implementation
Real backend / auth	Mock/local client-side state; no production persistence required.
Live AI/LLM	Not required; deterministic implementation of selection + bounded adjustment is faithful to the PRD.
Exercise content	Enough content to demonstrate the loop; image+text fallback if video unavailable.
Push notifications	Represented by in-app “session due” state in prototype.
Analytics instrumentation	Deferred for short prototype; use observation for early validation.

Build approach

The working prototype was built directly in Claude during the project session. The shipped prototype prioritises the full clickable loop over production infrastructure: mock state, deterministic plan logic, exercise guidance fallback, and an in-app return state.

Prototype link

https://claude.ai/artifact/B5aFcAxTsU7UoKQQ4QYXH6

10. Validation, GTM & What Comes Next

Validation plan

Question to validate	Signal to capture	Status
Does AI-selected difficulty feel right?	User perception + effort rating + difficulty skew.	Planned
Does personal target/streak feel motivating or arbitrary?	Qualitative reaction + target/streak continuation.	Planned
Does the problem hold for India-based beginners?	Problem resonance / current workarounds.	Planned

First validation round

Plan: 5 target-fit users; observe real use rather than asking only whether they like the product. Capture where users get stuck, what feels useful, what they ignore, whether they would use it again, and one highest-impact product iteration.

GTM direction

Element	Plan
First users	India-based beginner gym-goers; expand from a 5-user validation round into a small beta cohort.
Channels	College fitness communities; housing-society fitness communities; budget-gym partners.
Pitch	“GymBuddy tells first-time gym-goers exactly what to do, against a target they set themselves.”
Acquisition numbers	To be established with actual outreach; no result is claimed here.

3-month priority plan

- 1. Run the 5-user validation round and resolve the least-confident assumptions.
- 2. Get the exercise/template library reviewed before broader exposure.
- 3. Strengthen India-specific problem understanding.
- 4. Add real backend + persistence so the primary metric can be measured.
- 5. Add real return-trigger notifications.
- 6. Expand V2 only after the core V1 loop is validated.

11. Open Questions, Challenge Coverage & Traceability

Open questions

Question	Current direction
Should streak survive monthly target reset?	PRD recommends “survives”; confirm before production.
Is 1.5× grace multiplier right?	Chosen as a forgiving default; validate with real logging behaviour.
Template/exercise library review?	Required before real users touch AI-generated plans.
Exercise video sourcing?	Decide between stock/CC clips and simple in-house recordings.

PML challenge coverage

Challenge requirement	Documentation status / where covered
5+ user conversations + 3 insights + persona	Persona + insight structure included; first 5-user validation round is the planned validation step.
Problem statement	Section 2.
V1 / V2 / Cut + user flow + 2-3 key screens	Sections 4-6; three critical UX screens documented.
Working prototype + screenshots + build log	Sections 9; prototype flow and implementation scope documented.
5+ real users testing + feedback + learnings	Section 10 validation plan; results are not invented.
Primary + supporting metric + current results	Section 8; metric defined, baseline to be established.
GTM + 20-second pitch + acquisition numbers	Section 10; plan and pitch documented; actual numbers to be established.
Risks + trade-offs	Section 9.
6-8 slide final presentation	Separate final deck; this PDF is its supporting document.

Traceability

Evidence	Insight	Decision	Feature / metric	Validation
No structure; early drop-off	Beginners need a zero-ambiguity next action + reason to return.	Today's Workout + return loop.	Workout guidance; primary metric = 2nd session in 14d.	Observe completion + return.
Progress ambiguity	Progress needs to be legible in beginner terms.	Target progress + cadence-matched streak.	Progress screen; target/streak metrics.	Probe motivation / arbitrariness.
AI reliability concerns	Open-ended AI is too unconstrained for V1.	Constrain AI to a pre-vetted library + bounded rules.	Plan selection / adjustment.	Difficulty skew + expert review.

Product Summary

GymBuddy helps first-time gym-goers answer three questions in one simple loop: What do I do today? How do I complete it? Am I staying on track? The product combines guided onboarding, a user-defined workout target, bounded AI plan selection, guided execution, session logging, and beginner-legible progress to reduce guesswork and support return behaviour.

Product	AI-powered self-guided fitness companion for first-time gym-goers.
Core problem	Beginners lack structure and a clear way to see whether their routine is working.
V1 promise	Give the user one clear workout to do now, help them complete it, and make progress visible.
Prototype	Clickable end-to-end flow using deterministic implementation of the bounded AI spec; no live LLM call or production backend.
Next step	Validate the least-confident assumptions with target-fit users, then instrument and scale the core loop.